

important connection: “I have this social learning model in my classroom. There’s all this social stuff going on on the web.” His idea was to bring social peer-to-peer learning to people who could not afford an expensive class from Kaplan or Princeton Review or an even more expensive private tutor. From this insight Grockit was born.

Farb explains, “Whether you’re studying for the SAT or you’re studying for algebra, you study in one of three ways. You spend some time with experts, you spend some time on your own, and you spend some time with your peers. Grockit offers these three same formats of studying. What we do is we apply technology and algorithms to optimize those three forms.”

Farb is the classic entrepreneurial visionary. He recounts his original insight this way: “Let’s forget educational design up until now, let’s forget what’s possible and just redesign learning with today’s students and today’s technology in mind. There were plenty of multi-billion-dollar organizations in the education space, and I don’t think they were innovating in the way that we needed them to and I didn’t think we needed them anymore. To me, it’s really all about the students and I didn’t feel like the students were being served as well as they could.”

Today Grockit offers many different educational products, but in the beginning Farb followed a lean approach. Grockit built a minimum viable product, which was simply Farb teaching test prep via the popular online web conferencing tool WebEx. He built no custom software, no new technology. He simply attempted to bring his new teaching approach to students via the Internet. News about a new kind of private tutoring spread quickly, and within a few months Farb was making a decent living teaching online, with monthly revenues of \$10,000 to \$15,000. But like many entrepreneurs with ambition, Farb didn’t build his MVP just to make a living. He had a vision of a more collaborative, more effective kind of teaching for students everywhere. With his initial traction, he was able to raise money from some of the most prestigious investors in Silicon Valley.

When I first met Farb, his company was already on the fast track